

Professional Skills I: Presenting Lecture Notes, Day 4

Main point of this session:

Vocal variation - the technique by which a speaker keeps a listener engaged. Point of view - the technique by which we name the character's relationship to what they are saying in a given phrase. Can be characterized by introspection vs communication and vocal dynamics (pitch, rhythm, volume).

Learning objectives for today:

- Vocal Variation
- Point of View
- Introspection/Communication;
- Vocal Dynamics. Pitch, Rhythm, Volume

Meditation session (10-15 min)

Lie down

Stretch and get comfortable

Close your eyes, or keep them open if you prefer

Feel your breath...

Feel the ground beneath you supporting you...

Try to enter a state of embodiment, without interruption from the language-based, intellectual mind

If any of your muscles are tense, try to relax them: relax your face, jaw, ears, neck, shoulders, spine, arms, wrists, hands, fingers, legs, ankles, toes.

Now, if you've had your eyes closed, open them

Let your eyes softly gaze around the room, noticing shapes, color, and texture...

Now find a spot on the wall or ceiling, and let your eyes rest there...

Notice the spot in exquisite detail...

Now let your eyes move around the room, noticing shadows and objects...

Review (10 mins)

Concentration. Relaxation. Meaningful gesture. Home bases. Theatrical Sphere of Expression. Phrasing. Breathing during phrasing. Acting the behavior of thinking. Vocal

Variation: point of view, introspection / communication, vocal dynamics (pitch, rhythm and volume).

Exact definitions:

Concentration - ability to enter a state of embodiment without interruption from the language-based, intellectual mind

Relaxation - ability to use only the muscular energy needed at any given time, no more and no less

Meaningful gesture - specific use of physicality / gesture to support the clarity of your storytelling (as opposed to random, vague or meaningless gesture born from a lack of concentration / relaxation)

Home bases - a form of meaningful gesture; "resting" postures for a character
Breathing, gazing, grounding - tools for practicing concentration and relaxation

Theatrical Sphere of Expression - the distance we need to fill physically and vocally to be clearly seen, heard and understood in a theatrical space

Phrasing - the technique by which a speaker breaks up memorized text into understandable units (i.e. phrases); proper phrases are created by breathing in through the mouth at the punctuation, then speaking the phrase on the exhalation

Acting the behavior of thinking - together with our phrases, we must act out the behavior accompanying the character's thought process

Vocal variation - the technique by which a speaker keeps a listener engaged; the technique by which a speaker helps the listener understand the content and structure of a speech; the technique by which an actor makes distinct, dynamic shifts in vocal and acting choices from phrase to phrase

Point of view - the technique by which we name the character's relationship to what they are saying in a given phrase.

Introspection / communication - any point of view can be played in one of two directions: an introspective acting choice has the quality of still being in process, or more for the speaker than for the listener; a communicative acting choice has the quality of being fully processed and for the listener more than the speaker

Vocal Dynamics - pitch, rhythm and volume

Activity (10 minutes, parallel processing)

Everyone get up all. Take the paper with your text. Walk around the room. When you hit a wall, bounce in a new direction. Now, walk more quickly! ... Now, stop where you are. Wherever you are looking, stop. Take 10 seconds to concentrate and relax. Now pull out your text and read it. Practice breathing in on phrases, feeling your feet, staying relaxed. ... (almost immediately) No! Stop. That's not loud enough. Try again! (Get out of Nash equilibrium of people speaking too softly and not knowing when to start.)

Now, sit down. We've come really far. We've learned lots of techniques to control our body on stage, to make specific choices with our gestures and voice, and to act the behavior of thinking to guide the audience on our emotional journey. Next week, we will cover a few more techniques. But today and tomorrow, let's practice the ones we've learned. In this class it doesn't take long to say the lessons, but it takes a long time to be able to do them.

Exercise (30 minutes, focus on physicality)

Students come up one at a time, in front of us. Concentrate and relax for 10 seconds. Then students speak the first three sentences of their texts, exercising phrasing, and theatrical sphere of expression, while not forgetting concentration and relaxation.

Focus on meaningful gestures and home bases.

— BREAK (5 minutes) —

Exercise (30 minutes, focus on voice)

Students come up one at a time, in front of us. Concentrate and relax for 10 seconds. Then students speak the first three sentences of their texts, exercising phrasing, and theatrical sphere of expression, while not forgetting concentration and relaxation.

Focus on vocal variation (introspective vs. communicative; pitch, rhythm, volume)

Students discuss what they learned from watching peers (10 minutes)

Announcement: the speech you are writing in HWFIP to present next week is only for practicing your rhetoric and presentation skills. You can still do whatever project you want for ULTA, regardless of what you choose to talk about in your speech.